

Dispelling concerns: On Modi visit and India-Sri Lanka ties

Modi's **visit** to Colombo **should** help **advance** ties and resolve disputes

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's **visit** to Sri Lanka, (April 4-6), his first after 2019, **demonstrated**, beyond **optics**, the close ties between the two countries. **Colombo**, under the Janatha Vimukthi Peramuna (JVP)-led National People's Power (NPP) **regime**, **is** serious about improving relations with New Delhi. This was **evident** from the **conferment** of its highest honour for foreign leaders on Mr. Modi and a memorandum of understanding (MoU) on defence cooperation, billed as the first of its kind in **bilateral** ties. The JVP's **ascension** to power, **following** Anura Kumara Dissanayake's victory in the presidential poll in September 2024, and the NPP's **resounding** parliamentary election victory two months later, **gave room to** the **perception** that there would be a strictly formal, if not **cold**, relationship with India, **given** the JVP's anti-India posture of the past. There was also **apprehension** that Colombo might not be sensitive to New Delhi's security concerns. However, to be fair to him, Mr. Dissanayake **reiterated** his country's **long-standing** position that Sri Lanka would not **permit** its territory to be used against India's security and regional stability. Mr. Modi captured the **rationale** behind the MoU by saying that "the **security** of both countries **is** interconnected and co-dependent". Even though the MoU may have formalised certain **arrangements** in the area of defence, **bilaterally**, it is up to the NPP regime to **establish** that Sri Lanka means business in defence cooperation. But still, Sri Lanka is sure to be **conscious** that an **understanding** in 1987 not to let Trincomalee or any other Sri Lankan port be used for military purposes by a third country against India **has** not helped **dispel** India's concerns.

On the **vexatious** fishermen's issue — one of importance to Tamil Nadu — it was a good sign that there were detailed discussions. But Mr. Modi's visit should **trigger** a **full-fledged** discussion between the fishing communities of the two countries, and one that is **overseen** by government officials. Recently, fishers on either side of the Palk Bay met and exchanged their views. If this meeting is to have some **meaning**, it should be followed up with another round of talks. A flexible approach will help create a **lasting** solution. Another significant outcome of the visit is that Tamil parties, in their meeting with Mr. Modi, **conveyed** the point that they recognised the significance of the Indo-Lanka **Accord** of 1987 **in pursuit of** achieving a political settlement for the Tamils and sought India's "legitimate involvement". There has been **criticism** even in Sri Lanka that many of the parties had not fully supported the Accord, which **paved the way for** the establishment of **provincial** councils as a measure of **devolution**. **New Delhi**, which can provide liberal economic **aid** for the **war-torn** Northern and Eastern provinces, **should play the role of** a **dispassionate** observer and **urge** every **stakeholder** to **pursue** democratic means to arrive at a **consensus**.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Advance** (verb) – promote, enhance, further, progress, move forward आगे बढ़ाना
2. **Demonstrate** (verb) – show, exhibit, display, prove, indicate प्रदर्शित करना
3. **Optics** (noun) – public perception, appearance, image, impression, presentation छवि / जनधारणा
4. **Regime** (noun) – government, administration, rule, leadership, authority शासन व्यवस्था
5. **Evident** (adjective) – clear, obvious, apparent, noticeable, visible स्पष्ट
6. **Conferment** (noun) – awarding, bestowal, presentation, granting, honoring प्रदान करना
7. **Bilateral** (adjective) – two-sided, mutual, reciprocal, involving both parties, joint द्विपक्षीय
8. **Ascension** (noun) – rise, elevation, promotion, advancement, accession उत्थान / सत्ता में आना
9. **Following** (preposition) – after, subsequent to, as a result of, next to, post के बाद
10. **Resounding** (adjective) – emphatic, overwhelming, strong, decisive, powerful प्रभावशाली
11. **Give room to** (phrase) – allow, create space for, permit, enable, open up संभावना उत्पन्न करना
12. **Perception** (noun) – view, opinion, belief, impression, interpretation धारणा
13. **Cold** (adjective) – distant, unfriendly, indifferent, aloof, detached बेरुखा
14. **Given** (preposition) – considering, in view of, taking into account, based on, due to देखते हुए
15. **Apprehension** (noun) – fear, anxiety, worry, concern, unease आशंका
16. **Reiterate** (verb) – repeat, affirm, restate, emphasize, declare again दोहराना
17. **Long-standing** (adjective) – enduring, long-established, time-tested, historic, persistent लंबे समय से चला आ रहा
18. **Permit** (verb) – allow, authorize, enable, sanction, let अनुमति देना
19. **Rationale** (noun) – reason, justification, basis, explanation, logic कारण / औचित्य
20. **Arrangement** (noun) – agreement, setup, understanding, deal, structure व्यवस्था

21. **Bilaterally** (adverb) – mutually, jointly, between two parties, two-sidedly, reciprocally द्विपक्षीय रूप से
22. **Establish** (verb) – set up, build, create, confirm, institute स्थापित करना
23. **Conscious** (adjective) – aware, alert, mindful, attentive, informed जागरूक
24. **Dispel** (verb) – eliminate, remove, dismiss, drive away, clear दूर करना
25. **Vexatious** (adjective) – troubling, annoying, irritating, problematic, contentious कष्टप्रद / विवादास्पद
26. **Trigger** (verb) – initiate, start, spark, provoke, set off शुरू करना
27. **Full-fledged** (adjective) – complete, developed, established, thorough, mature पूर्ण रूप से विकसित
28. **Oversee** (verb) – supervise, monitor, manage, control, direct निगरानी रखना
29. **Meaning** (noun) – significance, implication, interpretation, message, essence अर्थ / महत्व
30. **Lasting** (adjective) – enduring, permanent, sustained, long-term, continuing स्थायी
31. **Convey** (verb) – communicate, express, deliver, relay, articulate व्यक्त करना
32. **Accord** (noun) – agreement, treaty, pact, deal, understanding समझौता
33. **In pursuit of** (phrase) – in search of, in quest of, striving for, aiming for, chasing के प्रयास में
34. **Legitimate** (adjective) – lawful, rightful, valid, reasonable, authorized वैध / उचित
35. **Criticism** (noun) – disapproval, censure, critique, condemnation, objection आलोचना
36. **Pave the way for** (phrase) – facilitate, lead to, enable, prepare for, make possible मार्ग प्रशस्त करना
37. **Provincial** (adjective) – regional, local, district-level, territorial, state-level प्रांतीय
38. **Devolution** (noun) – decentralization, delegation, transfer of power, distribution, allotment सत्ता का विकेंद्रीकरण
39. **Aid** (noun) – help, support, assistance, relief, contribution सहायता
40. **War-torn** (adjective) – conflict-affected, devastated, ravaged, battle-damaged, destroyed by war युद्ध-ग्रस्त
41. **Play the role of** (phrase) – act as, serve as, function as, take on the role, represent भूमिका निभाना

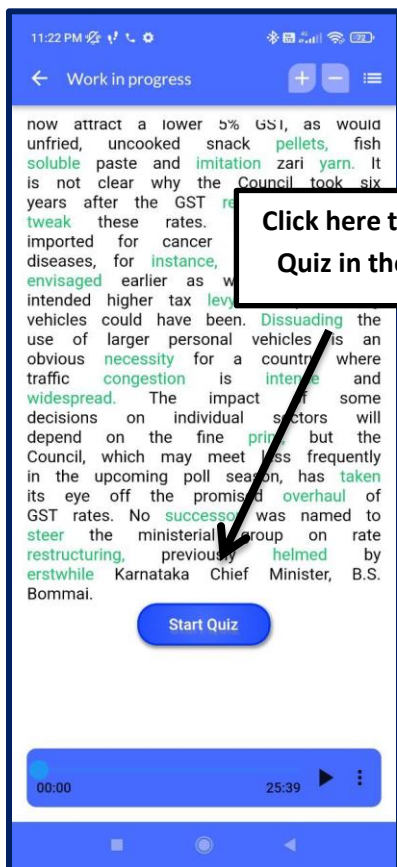
42. **Dispassionate** (adjective) – impartial, unbiased, neutral, objective, unemotional
निष्पक्ष
43. **Urge** (verb) – encourage, press, recommend, advise, push प्रेरित करना / आग्रह करना
44. **Stakeholder** (noun) – participant, interested party, partner, contributor, involved entity हितधारक
45. **Pursue** (verb) – follow, strive for, chase, engage in, seek प्रयास करना
46. **Consensus** (noun) – agreement, harmony, general opinion, unity, collective view आम सहमति

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Summary of the Editorial

1. **Historic Visit** – PM Modi visited Sri Lanka (April 4–6) for the first time since 2019, signaling a renewed bilateral focus.
2. **Strengthened Ties** – The visit reflected strong India–Sri Lanka ties beyond ceremonial gestures.
3. **High Honour** – Sri Lanka conferred its highest civilian honour for foreign leaders on PM Modi.
4. **Landmark MoU** – A new MoU on defence cooperation was signed—the first such formal agreement between the nations.
5. **Political Shift in Colombo** – The JVP-led NPP government, once seen as anti-India, now shows commitment to friendly relations.
6. **Past Apprehensions** – India was initially wary of the NPP due to its historic anti-India stance.
7. **Security Assurance** – President Dissanayake reassured that Sri Lankan territory won't be used to threaten India's security.
8. **Mutual Security** – PM Modi emphasized interconnected and co-dependent security for both countries.
9. **Need for Action** – While the MoU is a positive step, Sri Lanka must now prove its sincerity in defence collaboration.
10. **1987 Agreement Context** – Despite past understandings (like in 1987), India's concerns about port use remain.
11. **Fishermen's Issue** – The contentious issue, vital for Tamil Nadu, was discussed in detail.
12. **Community Dialogue** – India and Sri Lanka should facilitate formal, sustained dialogue between fishermen of both sides.
13. **Follow-up Needed** – A recent fisher dialogue must be followed by official, structured discussions for lasting solutions.
14. **Tamil Concerns** – Tamil parties reiterated the importance of the 1987 Indo-Lanka Accord in seeking political settlement and devolution.
15. **India's Role** – India should act as a neutral facilitator, offering economic aid and promoting democratic consensus-building in Sri Lanka's Northern and Eastern provinces.

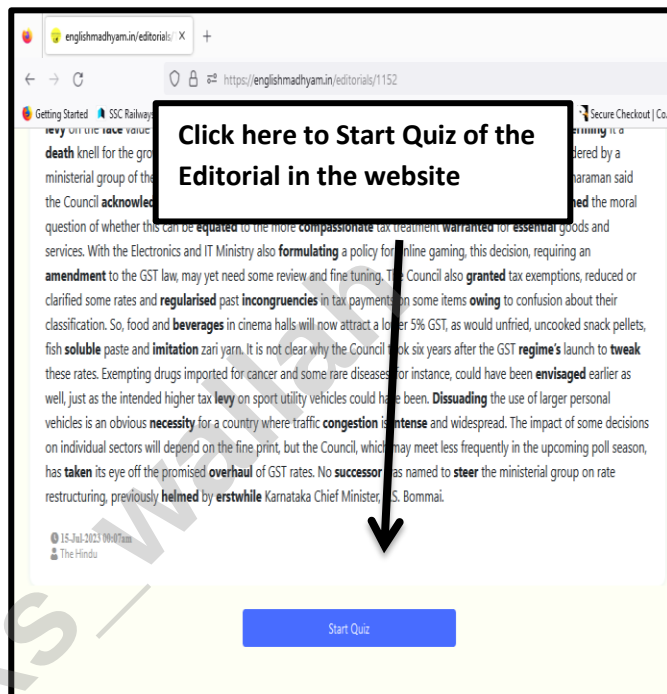
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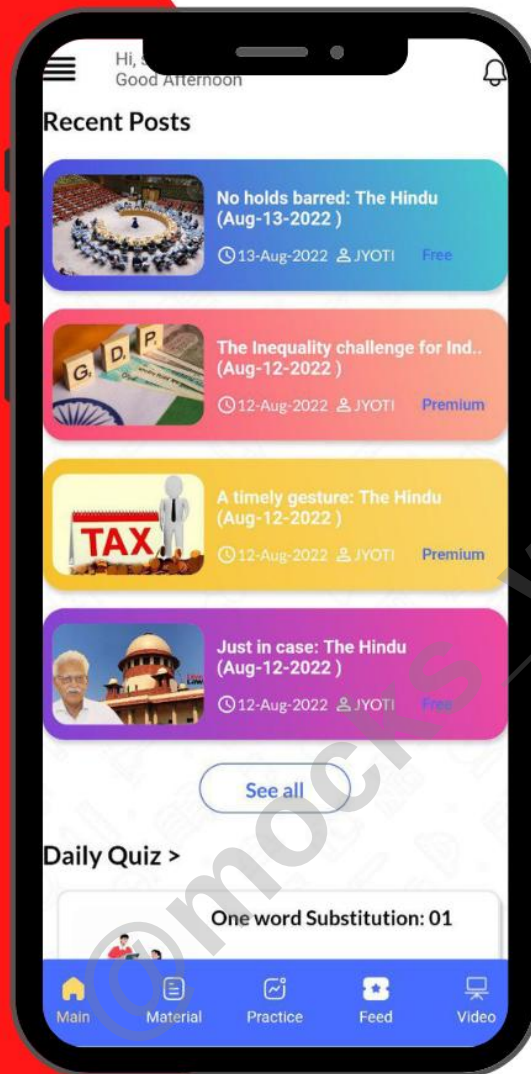
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